

Laws of The North

1. Justice

- 1.1. The law of the North holds that the man who passes the sentence must swing the sword. A lord who will not look a condemned man in the eye and kill him personally is unworthy of the weight of command.
- 1.2. **Judgments before the Heart Tree**
 - 1.2.1. Matters of grave import, including trials for treason and oath-breaking, are to be judged before the heart tree in the godswood, where the old gods bear witness.
 - 1.2.2. No man may tell a lie before a weirwood, for the old gods see through the carved faces and know when men speak false.
 - 1.2.3. Oaths sworn before the heart tree are considered the most binding of all vows, and their violation is punishable by death or exile to the Wall.
- 1.3. Lords of the North bring disputes before the Warden of the North at Winterfell. Lesser disputes between smallfolk are resolved by the lord of the nearest holdfast.

2. Guest Right

- 2.1. When a guest eats the food and drinks the drink of his host beneath the host's roof, guest right is invoked.
 - 2.1.1. Bread and salt are the traditional offering by which guest right is conferred. Once a guest has partaken, neither host nor guest may do harm to the other for the duration of the stay.
 - 2.1.2. The violation of guest right is considered an abomination before the old gods and the new. Those who break it are accursed and unfit to rule.
 - 2.1.3. Northmen hold guest right more sacred than any other custom, for to be denied food and shelter during winter is to be sentenced to death by the cold.
- 2.2. A lord who fails to offer bread and salt to a guest arriving at his gates brings dishonor upon his house. While not punishable by law, such a lord may find his bannermen unwilling to answer his call.
- 2.3. A lord who violates guest right forfeits his lands

and titles. His vassals are released from their oaths of fealty to him.

3. Religion

- 3.1. The old gods of the forest are the gods of the North. Worship is conducted before heart trees in the godswoods, not in temples or septs.
 - 3.1.1. There is no organized clergy among the followers of the old gods. Each man prays as he sees fit, and lords serve as the spiritual heads of their own households.
 - 3.1.2. The destruction or desecration of a weirwood is a grave offense. A man who cuts down a heart tree brings the wrath of the old gods upon himself and his kin.
 - 3.1.3. While septs exist in White Harbor and a small number of southern settlements, the Faith of the Seven holds no authority in the North, and its clergy may not pass judgment on Northmen.
- 3.2. Marriage in the North is performed before the heart tree, and no marriage is considered valid in the eyes of the old gods unless the bride and groom speak their vows in the presence of a weirwood.

4. Oaths and Fealty

- 4.1. The lords of the North swear their oaths of fealty to House Stark of Winterfell, the Wardens of the North, before the heart tree.
 - 4.1.1. A lord who renounces his oath of fealty is guilty of treason and subject to execution by the hand of the Warden.
 - 4.1.2. When called to war, every Northern lord must answer the summons of Winterfell or forfeit his lands and titles.
- 4.2. Bannermen owe their liege lord taxes, counsel, and military service. In return, the liege lord owes justice, protection, and fair dealing.
- 4.3. Oaths sworn under duress or by force of threat are not considered binding in the sight of the old gods. A man compelled to swear against his will may renounce his oath without dishonor.

5. Inheritance

- 5.1. The eldest son inherits his father's lands and titles. If there are no sons, the eldest daughter inherits.
 - 5.1.1. A lord may not disinherit his trueborn children in favor of a bastard, unless no trueborn heirs remain.
 - 5.1.2. A bastard may be legitimized only by royal

decree, whereupon he takes his father's name and enters the line of succession behind all trueborn children.

- 5.2. When a lord dies without heirs, his lands and titles revert to his liege lord, who may grant them to a vassal of his choosing.
- 5.3. A man who takes the black forfeits all claims to inheritance. His rights pass to the next in line as though he were dead.

6. Forbidden Practices

6.1. Flaying

- 6.1.1. The flaying of living men, whether as punishment or torture, is forbidden by the law of the Starks. This decree was made after the defeat of the Red Kings of House Bolton a thousand years past.
- 6.1.2. Any lord who orders or permits the flaying of a prisoner forfeits his lands. His household is subject to the judgment of Winterfell.

6.2. Right of the First Night

- 6.2.1. The right of the first night, by which a lord claims the bed of a vassal's bride on the night of her wedding, was abolished by King Jaehaerys I Targaryen two hundred years past.
- 6.2.2. Though the practice persists in certain remote holdfasts, any lord found to exercise this right may be stripped of his titles and brought before the Warden for judgment.

6.3. Kinslaying

- 6.3.1. Kinslaying is held to be the gravest of all sins before the old gods. A man who slays his own blood is accursed.
- 6.3.2. While kinslaying carries no fixed penalty in law, no Northern lord will shelter or treat with a known kinslayer, and his name is struck from the histories of his house.

7. The Wall and the Gift

- 7.1. The North bears the principal duty of supplying and defending the Wall.
 - 7.1.1. The New Gift, a stretch of land extending twenty-five leagues south of the Wall, is set aside for the support of the Night's Watch. The villages and holdfasts within the Gift pay their taxes in kind to the Watch, not to the Crown.
 - 7.1.2. Lords of the North are expected to send surplus men, provisions, and arms to the Wall,

particularly in the years before winter.

7.2. Night's Watch Deserters

- 7.2.1. A man who deserts the Night's Watch is sentenced to death. The lord who captures him carries out the sentence.
- 7.2.2. No man may give shelter, food, or aid to a known deserter of the Watch. To do so is to share in his crime and face the same penalty.
- 7.3. The Night's Watch takes no part in the wars of the realm, and no lord may call upon the men of the Watch to fight on his behalf.

8. Winter Laws

- 8.1. Preparation for winter is not merely custom but obligation. A lord who fails to store adequate grain and provisions for his people may be called to account by the Warden.
 - 8.1.1. During years of summer, lords are expected to set aside no less than one-fifth of each harvest for the winter stores.
 - 8.1.2. The deliberate destruction or hoarding of winter stores during famine is punishable as murder, for to deprive men of food in winter is to sentence them to death.
- 8.2. In times of deep winter, the smallfolk of the countryside may shelter within the winter town outside Winterfell. No lord may turn away those seeking refuge from the cold.
- 8.3. When the stores grow thin, it is a custom among old men of the North to announce they are going hunting, so that the young may have more to eat. This sacrifice is honored and remembered.

9. Wildlings and the Border

- 9.1. The lands beyond the Wall are outside the law of the North. Those who dwell there are not subjects of the Warden and owe no fealty to Winterfell.
 - 9.1.1. Wildlings who cross south of the Wall without leave are considered raiders and may be killed or captured at the discretion of the lord whose lands they enter.
 - 9.1.2. Trade with wildlings is not forbidden, but no lord may sell them weapons, armor, or steel.
- 9.2. The crannogmen of the Neck are sworn bannermen of House Stark and are subject to the laws of the North, despite their unusual customs. Their lord, the Lord of Greywater Watch, has the right to deny passage through the Neck to any army not bearing the banner of the Warden.

10. Hunting and Poaching

- 10.1. Game within a lord's forest belongs to that lord. Poaching is punishable by the loss of a hand or, at the lord's discretion, service on the Wall.
- 10.2. During winter, a lord may open his forests to the smallfolk so that they might hunt for survival. This grant is temporary and expires with the coming of spring.
- 10.3. The hunting of direwolves is forbidden throughout the North, for the direwolf is the sigil of House Stark and is held sacred.

11. Thievery

- 11.1. A thief may be punished by the loss of a finger or a hand, at the judgment of the lord.
- 11.2. Those who steal from the godswood or from before the heart tree are considered to have stolen from the gods themselves, and the punishment is death.
- 11.3. In times of winter, a man who steals food to feed his starving children may plead mercy before his lord. The lord is not obliged to grant it, but custom holds that such a man should be shown leniency.

Citations:

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